

# Stress Toolkit

Your map for Module 4 · Stress Management and Emotional Wellness · Nurture your heart

## Read this page first: support and safety

These tools help most people feel better. They are not a substitute for professional care. **Seek support** if you have low mood or anxiety on most days for two weeks or more, if sleep, appetite or concentration are falling apart, if you're withdrawing from people you love, or if you feel hopeless. **Seek help today** (your doctor, a crisis line, or emergency services) if you have any thoughts of harming yourself. Fertility counselling is a recognised specialty; many clinics have a counsellor, and organisations such as RESOLVE (US) and Fertility Network (UK) list support groups and therapists. The ESHRE guideline on psychosocial care in fertility (Gameiro et al., *Human Reproduction*) recommends routine screening and referral. Therapy is one of the tools.

## Why stress matters, and why it isn't your fault

- Stress hormones can dampen the brain's signals to the ovaries and testes (Whirlledge & Cidlowski, *Minerva Endocrinologica*).
- In the LIFE study, women with the highest salivary stress marker had 29% lower monthly fecundability and more than double the risk of infertility (Lynch et al., *Human Reproduction*, 2014).
- Pre-treatment distress was **not** associated with fertility-treatment outcome (Boivin et al., *BMJ*, 2011): your anxiety did not cause a negative test.
- Psychosocial interventions reduced distress and were associated with higher pregnancy rates (Frederiksen et al., *BMJ Open*, 2015).

## The seven tools on one page

| TOOL                                                                                      | TIME                    | USE IT WHEN                                          | TRAINING |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>5-minute body scan</b> (Meditation Audio)                                              | 5 min, daily, same time | every morning; 3 a.m. worry                          | T1       |
| <b>Breathing:</b> physiological sigh · box · 4-7-8 · six-a-minute                         | 10 s – 2 min            | waiting rooms, cravings, before calls, at the pillow | T2       |
| <b>Journaling:</b> big why, fears, hope/impatience, gratitude, "right now I feel", letter | 10–15 min, 3×/ week     | processing, pattern spotting                         | T3       |

| TOOL                                        | TIME                 | USE IT WHEN                            | TRAINING |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>Gratitude share</b> with partner or self | 3 min at bedtime     | every night, especially hard ones      | T4       |
| <b>Emotion wheel + coping plan</b>          | 5 min                | when a feeling arrives; before it does | T5       |
| <b>Sleep routine</b>                        | evening              | every night; phone in the kitchen      | T6       |
| <b>7-day stacked challenge</b>              | ≈25 min/day by day 7 | to lower your baseline                 | T7       |

## Module 4 at a glance

| TRAINING                                   | RUNTIME | RESOURCE                          | ACTIONS (XP)                                           | TOTAL |
|--------------------------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| T1 · Mindfulness Meditation Intro (guided) | 10      | Meditation Audio.mp3 + script/log | Meditate 5 min daily 40 · Journal 30 · Share 20        | 90    |
| T2 · Breathing Techniques for Calm         | 8       | Breath Guide.pdf                  | Try 3 techniques 30 · Use in real stress 40            | 70    |
| T3 · Journaling for Emotional Release      | 12      | Journal Prompts.pdf               | 3 entries 50 · Review patterns 30 · Share (anon.) 20   | 100   |
| T4 · Gratitude Practices for Couples       | 9       | Gratitude Cards.pdf               | Practice with partner 40 · Log 7 days 30               | 70    |
| T5 · Handling Fertility Emotions           | 11      | Emotion Wheel.pdf                 | Identify 1 emotion 30 · Coping plan 40 · Forum post 20 | 90    |
| T6 · Sleep Optimization for Stress         | 10      | Sleep Hygiene.pdf                 | Implement routine 40 · Track quality 30                | 70    |
| T7 · Emotional Wellness Challenge          | 12      | Challenge Log.pdf                 | Daily practices 50 · Reflect on calm 30 · Share 20     | 100   |
| Module completion bonus                    |         |                                   |                                                        | 10    |

## Your "why" for this module

*"I'm caring for my heart because, for my future family, I want \_\_\_\_\_."*

Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.